REWIND: An Immersive AR Surgical Training Tool

Victor Dunagan[1,2], Nathan Hammond[1,2], Nick Cui[1], Audrey Hardtke[1], Aaron Falconer[1,2]

[1]Department of Biomedical Engineering, Vanderbilt University, Nashville, TN

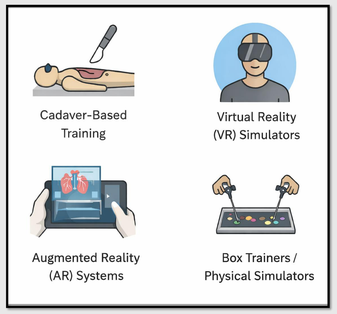
[2]Department of Electrical Engineering, Vanderbilt University, Nashville, TN

INTRODUCTION

- Surgical training relies on cadaver labs and learning in the OR, methods that are expensive, difficult to repeat, and don't always translate to real OR performance.
- AR/VR simulation offers a safe, repeatable, and scalable alternative to cadaveric simulations, especially for minimally invasive procedures
- Current AR simulators struggle to be adopted mainly due to the challenge of replicating compliant, deformable tissue behavior in real-time
- Haptic feedback addresses this problem through providing a way to replicate the "feel" of soft tissue, helping trainees develop their techniques, apply more appropriate forces, and retain their skills longer

Our solution: a closed-loop AR + haptic glove system that bridges this gap, combining joint-angle sensing, ROS-based haptic force feedback control, and Unity AR rendering to provide immersive, haptic-feedback reinforced surgical training.

PREVIOUS SOLUTIONS



Cadaver-Based Training
- Gold standard for realism but limited by cost, availability, and repeatability ; No measurable performance feedback

Virtual Reality (VR) Simulators
- Immersive but lack physical interaction

Augmented Reality (AR) Systems
- Enhance visualization but lack closed-loop interaction and realistic force feedback

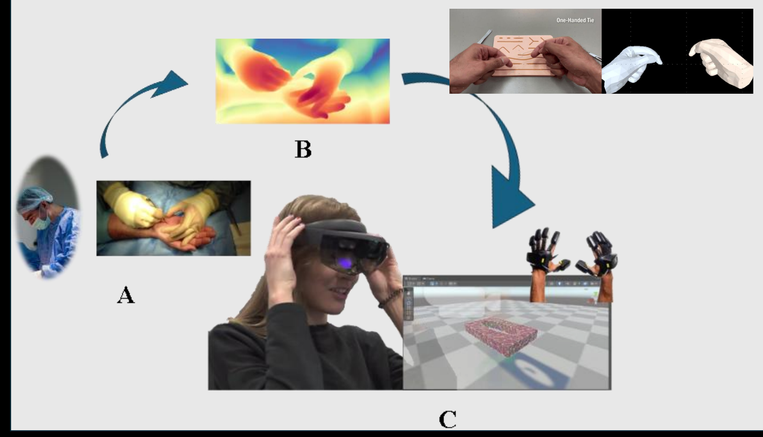
Box Trainers / Physical Simulators
- Common in minimally invasive surgery training; Provide hands-on practice but lack adaptability and real-time guidance

Gap in Existing Solutions
- Lack of integrated AR + full-hand haptics systems
- Limited performance evaluation and feedback within training systems
- Lack of realistic hands to follow along with in training environments
- Insufficient realism in soft tissue deformation + force interaction simultaneously

NEEDS

Current AR training tools lack accurate haptic feedback and repeatability, limiting skill development and prolonging surgical training time.

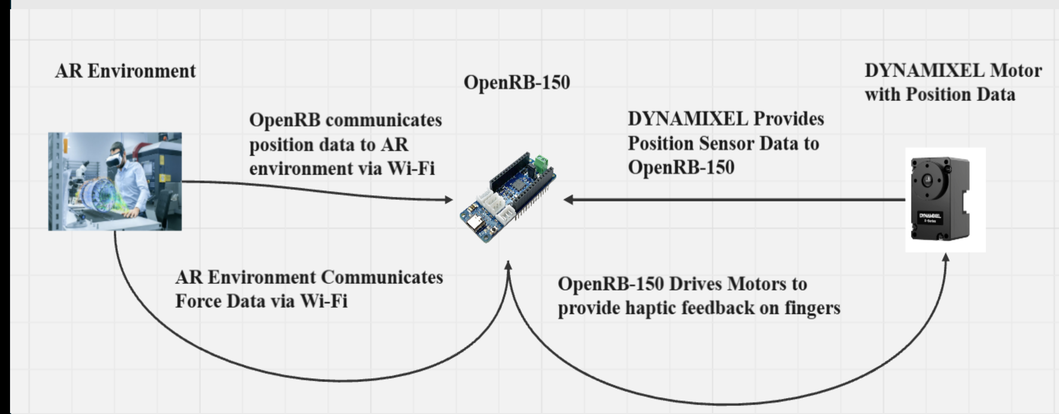
3D RECONSTRUCTION



MECHANICAL GLOVE DESIGN

mechanical glove design

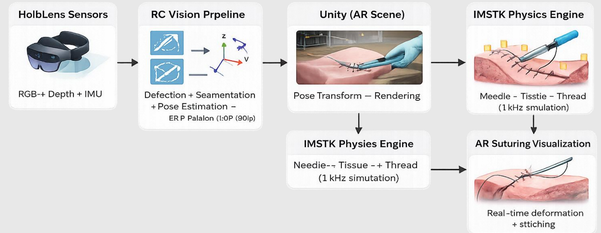
ELECTRONICS



AUGMENTED REALITY

The Unity scene connects real-time instrument tracking with a physics-based suturing simulation. A PC vision pipeline streams 6-DoF instrument poses to Unity, where they are transformed and used to drive a virtual needle. This enables markerless tracking to directly control the simulated instrument in real time.

Within Unity, the physics engine simulates needle–tissue–thread interaction. A state machine governs insertion, while physics-based constraints drive tissue deformation, suture pull-through, and wound closure. This creates a closed-loop system where real-world motion produces realistic, physically accurate AR surgical behavior.



NEXT STEPS

- Improve realism of haptic feedback to better mimic soft tissue behavior
- Reduce system latency for smoother real-time interaction
- Expand AR scenarios to simulate full surgical procedures
- Integrate more advanced tracking and sensor fusion methods
- Conduct user studies to evaluate training outcomes and usability
- Transition toward a more portable and scalable system design

[1] S. Mitani *et al.*, "Augmented reality-enhanced cadaver surgical training for head and neck surgeons: a proof-of-concept study," *Global Surgical Education - Journal of the Association for Surgical Education*, vol. 5, no. 1, Dec. 2025, doi: https://doi.org/10.1007/s44186-025-00420-3.

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Intro/bg

Existing solns/previous design solns

needs

Computer vision

mechanical glove design

electronics

AR / Unity scene

Conclusion / next steps

Ack & references